

C4 – STRONG JOB MARKET VS WORKER INSTABILITY

(Contradictions Ledger – Evidence Sheet)

I. THE OFFICIAL NARRATIVE ("WORDS")

Officials describe the American labor market as “strong,” “historic,” and “delivering for families,” citing low unemployment, job creation, and rising wages. Statements emphasize:

- “Historic job creation.”
- “Wages are rising.”
- “The labor market is extremely tight.”
- “Broad-based economic growth.”

These statements frame job quantity as proof of worker well-being, without addressing job quality or stability.

II. HOUSEHOLD OUTCOMES ("OUTCOMES")

1. Real Wage Decline

BLS data shows real wages fell 1.5% in 2021 and 3% in 2022, with only minimal recovery in 2023.

2. Multiple Jobholding at Multi-Decade Highs

Over 5.4% of workers—about 8.8 million people—hold multiple jobs, the highest since 2009.

3. Involuntary Part-Time Work

More than 4.3 to 4.6 million Americans work part-time because they cannot find full-time work.

4. Difficulty Paying Basic Expenses

Census Pulse Survey: 36.4% of households (over one-third) struggle to cover usual bills.

5. Declining Financial Security

Federal Reserve SHED report: Adults “doing at least okay financially” fell from 78% (2021) to 72% (2023), the lowest since 2016.

These outcomes contradict assurances of a strong labor market, showing workers in fragile and unstable conditions.

III. THE CONTRADICTION

Public statements rely on job counts and unemployment rates to portray strength. But government data shows:

- Declining real wages.
- Rising multiple jobholding.
- High involuntary part-time work.
- Increased financial hardship.
- Declining household well-being.

One-sentence summary:

A “strong” job market masks declining real wages, rising multiple jobholding, and widespread financial instability.

IV. HARM CHANNELS

- Financial instability from fluctuating hours and low pay.
- Burnout from working multiple jobs.
- Difficulty securing housing with unstable income.
- Limited access to benefits from gig or part-time work.
- Increased family stress and child instability from unpredictable schedules.

V. APA ROUTING (AGENCY USE)

- vDOL: Real wage decline contradicts “strong job market” claims.
- vFED: Labor market “tightness” claims fail to reflect worker instability.
- vIRS: Income volatility undermines withholding assumptions.
- vHUD: Employment instability contributes to rent burden and evictions.
- vSSA: Instability harms disabled workers seeking consistent support.

This evidence challenges the accuracy and rationality of official labor-force narratives.